

scripts/check-subagent-delegation-audit.sh — User Guide

Last verified: 2026-05-18 (1.2.30-1050 tooling cycle)

Inheritance: HelixConstitution §11.4.x (subagent-delegation-audit-trail mandate) + Lava §6.AD-debt closure (CM-SUBAGENT-DELEGATION-AUDIT — THIRD and FINAL §6.AD-debt item)

Overview

When a commit message describes a SUBAGENT DISPATCH ACTIVITY (an agent-driven sub-task that landed work into this repo via the Agent tool or worktree-based delegation), the gate verifies a matching audit-trail entry exists under:

```
.lava-ci-evidence/subagent-dispatches/<YYYY-MM-DD>-<short-slug>.json
```

The audit trail makes subagent activity discoverable + auditable: which agent, when, for what purpose, with what outcome. Without it, a future operator (or future session) reading `git log` sees mentions of subagents but can't reconstruct context.

Audit-entry schema

```
{
  "dispatch_date":      "YYYY-MM-DD",
  "agent_type":         "general-purpose | Explore | code-
    reviewer | plugin-validator | code-modernization:legacy-
    analyst | ...",
  "purpose":           "one-line summary of what the
    subagent was tasked with",
  "dispatched_for_commit": "SHA OR 8-char short-SHA-prefix",
  "outcome":           "merged | discarded | failed |
    pending",

  "isolation":         "worktree |
    inline", // optional
  "worktree_branch":   "worktree-agent-XXXXXXX (if
    isolation=worktree)", // optional
```

```

    "findings_count":
        0, //
        optional
    "follow_ups": ["issue/url/
        SHA"] // optional
}

```

Minimum required fields: dispatch_date, agent_type, purpose, dispatched_for_commit.

Usage

Default – scan HEAD only

```
bash scripts/check-subagent-delegation-audit.sh
```

Range

```
bash scripts/check-subagent-delegation-audit.sh HEAD~5..HEAD
```

Unpushed (recommended pre-push)

```
bash scripts/check-subagent-delegation-audit.sh '@{u}..HEAD'
```

Env-var alternatives

```
LAVA_COMMIT_RANGE='HEAD~3..HEAD' bash scripts/check-subagent-
delegation-audit.sh
```

```
LAVA_REPO_ROOT=/path bash scripts/check-subagent-delegation-
audit.sh
```

```
LAVA_SUBAGENT_AUDIT_CUTOFF=2026-06-01 bash scripts/check-subagent-
delegation-audit.sh
```

Exit codes

Code	Meaning
0	No triggering commits found, OR every triggering commit has a matching audit entry
1	At least one post-cutoff triggering commit lacks an audit entry; commit SHA + trigger phrase printed to stderr

What counts as a "subagent dispatch" trigger

The scanner uses **action-paired** patterns to avoid false-positives on commits that merely mention "agent" or "subagent" in unrelated prose (e.g., the gate's own name CM-SUBAGENT-DELEGATION-AUDIT).

Triggering patterns (case-insensitive):

1. subagent <action> where action ∈ {landed, dispatched, merged, worktree, driven, discovered, surfaced, closed, spawned}
2. <action> [article|count] (sub)agent — e.g. dispatched the agent, merged a subagent, spawned 5th-wave agent
3. worktree-agent-[a-z0-9]{8,} — Claude Code branch convention (very specific, 8+ hex chars)
4. agent-driven — generic subagent-activity prose
5. agent worktree — generic
6. agent (landed|merged|surfaced|closed|finished) — passive-voice action

Whitelist conditions (intentional skips)

- **Blockquote lines** (lines starting with >).
- **4+ space indented lines** (heavy quoted-output / code-block-like prose; bullet continuations at 2-space indent still scanned).
- **Lines containing CM-SUBAGENT-DELEGATION-AUDIT** (gate-name self-reference).
- **Backtick spans** (`code`).
- **~~strikethrough~~ spans.**

Effective-from cutoff

Default LAVA_SUBAGENT_AUDIT_CUTOFF=2026-05-19. Commits BEFORE this date are grandfathered (no audit entry required). The cutoff exists because past commits (~30+ in last 30 days) referenced subagents without an audit-trail convention; backfilling all of them is not the right closure posture for this gate.

Override the cutoff to enforce on a different date.

§6.J anti-bluff falsifiability rehearsal

1. Make a post-cutoff commit with a subagent trigger phrase:

```
git commit --allow-empty -m "merge: subagent landed Phase X  
waiver backfill"
```

2. Run bash scripts/check-subagent-delegation-audit.sh → expect exit 1 with the commit SHA + trigger.
3. Either (a) create the audit entry under .lava-ci-evidence/subagent-dispatches/<date>*.json with dispatched_for_commit: <short-sha>, OR (b) git commit --amend removing the trigger.
4. Re-run → expect exit 0.

The deliberate-orphan rehearsal proves the gate fires on real audit gaps.

Integration

- Wired into `scripts/verify-all-constitution-rules.sh` as a standard gate (default scope: `HEAD~5..HEAD`).
- Pre-push hooks transitively run via `scripts/check-constitution.sh`.
- Recommended pre-push scope: `@{u}..HEAD` (all unpushed commits).

Hermetic test

`tests/check-constitution/test_subagent_delegation_audit.sh` — 8 fixtures:

1. No subagent triggers → pass
2. Pre-cutoff trigger → grandfathered → pass
3. Post-cutoff trigger without audit entry → reject (exit 1)
4. Post-cutoff trigger with matching audit entry → pass
5. Gate-name self-reference (no other trigger) → pass
6. `worktree-agent-X` branch-convention → trigger → reject (post-cutoff, no audit)
7. Backtick-quoted trigger phrase → skipped → pass
8. Real-repo HEAD sanity check → pass

Run:

```
bash tests/check-constitution/test_subagent_delegation_audit.sh
```

When to create an audit entry

Required (post-cutoff): any commit whose body describes one of:

- A subagent landed work into the tree (merge from `worktree-agent-X`, dispatched-then-merged work, agent-driven discovery).
- A subagent surfaced a finding that's referenced in the commit (e.g., subagent surfaced 3 bluffs).

Not required:

- Commits that mention the gate's name `CM-SUBAGENT-DELEGATION-AUDIT` without describing a dispatch.
- Commits that backtick-quote a trigger phrase as a literal string.

- Commits authored by the operator directly (no subagent involvement).

When not to use a subagent (and avoid this gate)

For routine tasks the main agent can complete in <3 tool calls, subagent dispatch is overhead. The gate exists to make NON-routine dispatches discoverable, not to encourage every task to spawn an agent.

Classification: project-specific (the convention is universal per HelixConstitution; the audit-dir path + cutoff date are Lava-specific).